

Fifty. Sixty.
Ninety.

THE BASICS

FOR

DATE

FROM

UNTIL

VENUE

ADDRESS

THE SHAPE OF IT

DRESS CODE

GUESTS

TABLES

BUDGET

RSVP BY

ORGANISER

CO-HOST

SURPRISE?

☐

YES

☐

NO

TURNING

years

THE TONE, IN THREE WORDS

THEN HOLD EVERY CHOICE TO IT

THE ONE THING THEY WOULD HATE

EVERY MILESTONE HAS ONE

COUNTDOWN

☐ 3 MONTHS

☐ 6 WEEKS

☐ 3 WEEKS

☐ 1 WEEK

☐ THE EVE

☐ THE DAY

NOTES



Three months to the day.

FOR _____
DATE _____

◆ Three months out

- ☐ Agree the date with the guest of honour — or with the one keeping the secret
- ☐ Set the budget and who is paying for what
- ☐ Draft the guest list, decade by decade
- ☐ Visit and book the venue
- ☐ Book the caterer and the photographer
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____

◆ Three weeks out

- ☐ Chase every guest who has not replied
- ☐ Confirm final numbers with the caterer
- ☐ Draft the seating plan
- ☐ Order the printing: menus, place cards
- ☐ Collect messages from those who cannot come
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____

◆ The day before

- ☐ Deliver whatever the venue will hold
- ☐ Charge everything: camera, speaker, laptop
- ☐ Lay out the gift table and the guest book
- ☐ Brief the helpers on the arrival plan
- ☐ Sleep — tomorrow is long
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____

◆ The day

- ☐ Set up and run the slideshow once, in the room
- ☐ One person on the door with the seating plan
- ☐ Speeches, toast, cake — in that order
- ☐ _____

◆ Six weeks out

- ☐ Send the invitations — posted, for this one
- ☐ Ask about dietary needs on the invitation
- ☐ Book the music, the flowers and the cake
- ☐ Ask three people to speak, and tell them the length
- ☐ Start collecting photographs for the slideshow
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____

◆ One week out

- ☐ Confirm every vendor in writing, with times
- ☐ Finish the slideshow and watch it through
- ☐ Send the running order to whoever is on the microphone
- ☐ Confirm the surprise choreography with the driver
- ☐ Print the seating plan and the running order
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____



Five decades
in one room.

FOR _____
DATE _____

III_{of XI}

GUESTS _____ FAMILY · SCHOOL · WORK · NEIGHBOURS · THE ONES WHO GO BACK FURTHEST

#	NAME	HOW THEY KNOW THEM	CONTACT	INV	YES	NO	+1	DIETARY
01	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
02	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
03	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
04	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
05	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
06	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
07	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
08	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
09	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
10	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
11	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
12	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
13	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
14	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
15	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
16	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
17	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
18	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
19	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
20	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
21	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
22	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
23	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____
24	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐	_____	_____

_____ INVITED _____ COMING _____ CAN'T _____ WAITING _____ TO SEAT



Keeping *the secret.*

FOR _____
DATE _____

IV^{of XI}

IS IT A SURPRISE? _____

SURPRISE ☐ YES ☐ NO — SKIP THIS PAGE

COVER STORY _____

WHO TELLS IT _____

WHAT THEY THINK IS HAPPENING _____

WHO BRINGS THEM _____

ARRIVES AT _____

GUESTS ARRIVE BY _____

WHERE CARS GO _____

WHO IS IN ON IT _____ EVERYONE BRIEFED GETS A TICK

NAME	THEIR JOB	TOLD
------	-----------	------

_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐

THE REVEAL, STEP BY STEP WRITE IT AS INSTRUCTIONS, NOT HOPES

- 1 _____
- 2 _____
- 3 _____
- 4 _____
- 5 _____

RULES FOR THE ROOM _____

- ☐ Phones on silent, no posting until after
- ☐ Nobody parks where they will be seen
- ☐ One person greets, everyone else stays quiet
- ☐ Camera running before the door opens

IF THEY FIND OUT _____ THERE IS ALWAYS A CHANCE

Who is booked,
what it costs.

FOR _____
DATE _____ V of XI

VENDORS _____ DEPOSIT PAID · CONFIRMED IN THE LAST FORTNIGHT

SERVICE	NAME	PHONE	COST	DEP	CNF
Venue	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐
Catering	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐
Bar	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐
Cake	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐
Photographer	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐
Music	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐
Flowers	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐
Printing	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐
Transport	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐
Hire	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐
_____	_____	_____	_____	☐	☐

THE BUDGET _____ DEPOSITS DUE _____ WHAT · WHEN · HOW MUCH

LINE	PLANNED	ACTUAL	
Venue hire	_____	_____	_____
Food	_____	_____	_____
Drink	_____	_____	_____
Cake	_____	_____	CURRENCY _____
Photography	_____	_____	HARD CEILING _____
Music	_____	_____	WHO PAYS WHAT _____
Flowers & styling	_____	_____	STILL TO PRICE _____ THE THREE THAT ALWAYS COME LATE
Printing	_____	_____	_____
Gifts & favours	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____
TOTAL	_____	_____	_____

The table itself.

FOR

DATE

VI_{of XI}

THE MENU

COURSE BY COURSE, AND WHO IS MAKING IT

COURSE	WHO / WHERE

THE CAKE

BAKER

FLAVOUR

SERVES

WRITTEN ON IT

DELIVERED AT

THE BAR

A BOTTLE OF WINE PER TWO GUESTS, OVER DINNER

WHAT	HOW MUCH

DIETARY NEEDS

COPY FROM THE GUEST LIST, TICK WHEN THE CATERER KNOWS

WHO	WHAT THEY NEED	TOLD
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐

☐ Caterer has the final list in writing



Who speaks,
and for how long.

FOR _____
DATE _____

VII_{of XI}

THE ORDER THREE SPEAKERS, FOUR MINUTES EACH. NOBODY HAS EVER WANTED MORE.

#	WHO	WHAT THEY WILL SAY	MINS	CNF
1	_____	_____	_____	☐
2	_____	_____	_____	☐
3	_____	_____	_____	☐
4	_____	_____	_____	☐
5	_____	_____	_____	☐
6	_____	_____	_____	☐

THE TOAST _____

LED BY _____

THE WORDS _____

CHARGED GLASSES BY _____

CARDS & THE PRESENT _____

PRESENTED BY _____

WHEN IN THE EVENING _____

WHERE IT WAITS _____

BEFORE ANYONE SPEAKS _____

- ☐ Microphone tested, in the room, with the doors shut
- ☐ Speakers know the order and their cue
- ☐ Water on the top table
- ☐ Music paused, not just turned down
- ☐ Camera on the guest of honour, not the speaker
- ☐ Someone ready to close it and move to the cake

INTRODUCED BY ONE VOICE RUNS THE EVENING

NAME _____

THEIR CUE CARD _____

NOTES _____



Photographs *and voices.*

FOR _____
DATE _____

VIII_{of XI}

PHOTOGRAPHS TO GATHER — ASK EARLY

DECADE	WHO HAS THEM	ASK	GOT	SCAN
--------	--------------	-----	-----	------

_____	_____	☐	☐	☐
_____	_____	☐	☐	☐
_____	_____	☐	☐	☐
_____	_____	☐	☐	☐
_____	_____	☐	☐	☐
_____	_____	☐	☐	☐
_____	_____	☐	☐	☐
_____	_____	☐	☐	☐
_____	_____	☐	☐	☐
_____	_____	☐	☐	☐

THE SLIDESHOW —

RUNS FOR _____

MUSIC _____

SHOWN AT _____

WHO RUNS IT _____

MESSAGES FROM THE ABSENT — READ TWO ALOUD

WHO	ASK	GOT	READ BY
-----	-----	-----	---------

_____	☐	☐	_____
_____	☐	☐	_____
_____	☐	☐	_____
_____	☐	☐	_____
_____	☐	☐	_____
_____	☐	☐	_____
_____	☐	☐	_____

TECH CHECK — DO THIS IN THE ROOM, NOT AT HOME

☐ Laptop, charger and the right adaptor

☐ Projector or screen tested with the actual file

☐ Sound through the room, not the laptop

☐ A copy of the file on a memory stick

☐ Someone who knows how to start it

NOTES —



Where everyone *sits.*

FOR _____
DATE _____

IX^{of XI}

TABLES _____ NAME THE TABLE, THEN FILL THE SEATS

I _____	2 _____	3 _____	4 _____
5 _____	6 _____	7 _____	8 _____

KEEP APART _____ EVERY FAMILY HAS A PAIR SEAT TOGETHER _____ THE ONES WHO WILL CARRY A TABLE

_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____

PLACE CARDS — PRINTED, CHECKED AGAINST THE FINAL LIST

☐ Names spelled the way they spell them



DATE _____

 $X_{of\ XI}$

TIME	WHAT HAPPENS	WHO IS ON IT
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DOORS, DRINKS, PHOTOGRAPHS

EVERYONE SEATED

DINNER SERVED

SPEECHES

CAKE AND THE TOAST

MUSIC

FAREWELLS

DO NOT FORGET

- ☐ Seating plan printed, twice
- ☐ Running order to the microphone
- ☐ Cake knife, and someone to cut it
- ☐ Guest book and a pen that works
- ☐ Gift table with somewhere to put cards
- ☐ Taxi numbers by the door
- ☐ Someone sober driving the guest of honour home

SET-UP & CLEAR-DOWN

ACCESS FROM

OUT BY

CLEAR-DOWN CREW

Thank yous *and keepsakes.*

FOR _____
DATE _____

XI_{of XI}

GIFTS ————— TICK WHEN THE THANK-YOU IS WRITTEN AND POSTED

#	WHAT IT WAS	WHO FROM	SENT
01	_____	_____	☐
02	_____	_____	☐
03	_____	_____	☐
04	_____	_____	☐
05	_____	_____	☐
06	_____	_____	☐
07	_____	_____	☐
08	_____	_____	☐
09	_____	_____	☐
10	_____	_____	☐
11	_____	_____	☐
12	_____	_____	☐
13	_____	_____	☐
14	_____	_____	☐
15	_____	_____	☐
16	_____	_____	☐

KEEP —————

- ☐ Guest book, signed
- ☐ The menu card and the running order
- ☐ Photographs shared with everyone who came
- ☐ The slideshow file, backed up
- ☐ Messages from those who could not come
- ☐ A note of what you would do again

WHAT WORKED —————

WHAT YOU WOULD CHANGE —————

